

TALES FROM THE TRENCHES: THE MANY FACES OF INDIA'S T20 PATHWAYS

A behind-the-scenes look at how India's domestic T20 leagues shape the **next generation** — and the quirks along the way.

A total of nine players from Madhya Pradesh featured in the recently concluded 2025 Indian Premier League (IPL) — eight of whom had come through the State's premier T20 competition, the MPLT20, in 2024. Just a week after the IPL final, the MPLT20 got underway in Gwalior on June 12 — and so did the work of talent scouts from franchises such as Mumbai Indians, Royal Challengers Bengaluru, Chennai Super Kings, and Rajasthan Royals, along with State selectors preparing for the season ahead. The Diary, too, found itself alongside these sharp-eyed

Scouting ground: From field placements to footwork under pressure — every ball is watched closely at Gwalior's MPLT20.

SAHIL MATHUR

observers. There are a few qualities they consistently seek in a player: skill across departments, fitness, temperament, and attitude. Even a century doesn't always guarantee notice. "You need to check the bowling quality — how they handle a quick bowler," said one IPL scout.

While the players try to stay locked into the game, the scouts make it a point not to miss a single delivery. At times, they count where the fielders are positioned, check whether the bowler adheres to the field setting, and observe if the batter responds to changes quickly. Amid all this, there's the occasional sideways glance at India's Test match unfolding in England.

Between matches, conversations wander — from updates across the domestic scene to nostalgic banter. Since many of these scouts are from different State associations,

swapping notes is par for the course.

When the Diary asked one of them to reflect on the constant travel, he shrugged with a grin: "I love it. Being on the move is fine, but watching cricket is always great fun."

Sahil Mathur

A TNPL matchday that refused to end

The Tamil Nadu Premier League (TNPL) drew a full house for the opening game of the 2025 season's final leg. Roughly 4,000 fans had gathered at the NPR College Ground in Natham, eager to watch local stars M. Shahrukh Khan and Vijay Shankar in action.

But nature had other plans. A torrential downpour just before the toss delayed the game between Chepauk Super Gillies (CSG) and Siechem Madurai Panthers (SMP) by nearly an hour. Spectators scrambled for shelter as the players watched the

